



Young guns: Jack Draper and Jakub Mensik impressed with some pretty solid wins against multiple seeded players at the Indian Wells and Miami Open.

With unstoppable momentum, Alcaraz smacked five winners to seize the climactic match tie-breaker, 10-2. On championship point, the charismatic Spaniard sprinted to pull off a dazzling forehand down-the-line winner to clinch the longest match in Roland Garros history, after 5 hours and 29 minutes. The finishing shot reminded everyone of the signature forehand of his boyhood idol Nadal, whose career, especially his record 14 French Open titles, was honoured in a farewell ceremony on opening day. Alcaraz said afterwards. "Best match that I've played in my career in a Grand Slam."

Earlier, with far less drama, Sinner had consolidated his recognition as the King of Hard Courts by winning his second Australian Open title, third overall, dropping only two sets against relatively weak opponents until the final, while avoiding both Alcaraz and Djokovic on the way. Sinner overpowered seven straight

foes, his ruthless domination culminating on the tournament's 120th birthday with a clinical 6-3, 7-6(4), 6-3 final triumph over Zverev. "You're the best player in the world by far," said the gracious loser.

Meanwhile, two rising stars blazed during the Sunshine Double on American hard courts. At Indian Wells, Jack Draper, a British lefty whose promising career has been stalled by injuries, overpowered Brazilian hotshot Joao Fonseca, No. 4 Taylor Fritz, No. 12 Shelton, and No. 13 Holger Rune in the final — all in straight sets.

Fate was kind to Jakub Mensik at the Miami Open. The 6'5" Czech power hitter had signed the papers to withdraw because of a painful knee, but the official wasn't available to accept them. As Mensik put it, "I was lucky the referee was having lunch." Instead, he went to a tour physiotherapist for 11th-hour treatment. "He did a miracle," Mensik

said. The 19-year-old capitalised on his good fortune and won all seven tie-breakers as he upset No. 7 Draper, No. 18 Arthur Fils, No. 4 Fritz, and Djokovic, his boyhood idol, 7-6 (4), 7-6 (4) in the final.

Cycle of revenge

For the first time in its 148-year history, Wimbledon replaced its snazzy-dressed but fallible line judges with AI ball-tracking on every court. Also noteworthy, 11 of the 32 gentlemen's seeds were eliminated in the first round, the highest being No. 3 Zverev, No. 7 and 2024 semifinalist Lorenzo Musetti, No. 8 Rune, and No. 9 Daniil Medvedev.

The carnage continued in the second round when 2014 U.S. Open champion and 2017 Wimbledon runner-up Marin Cilic, now 36, ousted Draper. Cilic used his 6'6" height, huge reach, and excellent backhand to return enough of Draper's booming serves for a 6-4, 6-3, 1-6, 6-4 upset.